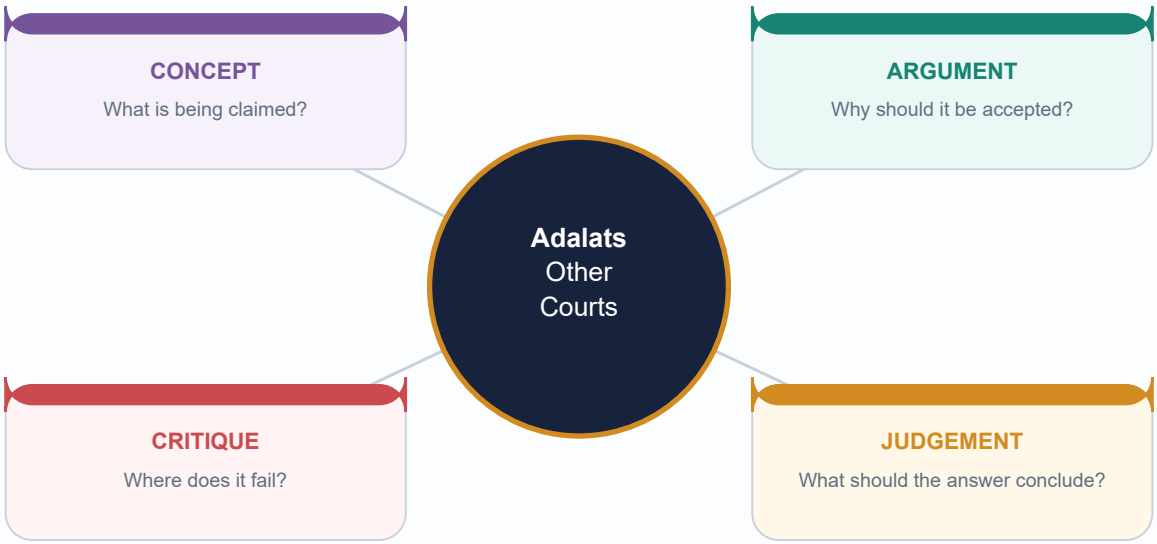
UPSC INDIAN POLITY

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth Deep-Learning Visual Notes

Indian Polity · GS Paper II · Prelims + Mains
Layer 1: Basic foundation · Layer 2: Advanced constitutional and exam depth
Sources: Lok-Adalats-and-Other-Courts.md + 54_Lok-Adalats-and-Other-Courts.md
Learning cards: 55



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Foundation · Core Foundation · Part 1

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Subject: Polity · **Tier:** Core · **GS Paper:** GS-II

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

CORE FOUNDATION: RECALL MAP

Core Foundation

V

Dimension 1 Subject: Polity · Tier: Core · GS Paper: GS-II	**Dimension 2** Official clause: "Structure, organization and functioning of the Executive and the Judiciary"
Dimension 3 and "mechanisms, laws, institutions and Bodies constituted for the protection and betterment of	**Dimension 4** these vulnerable sections."

STATIC THEORY

- **Official clause:** "Structure, organization and functioning of the Executive and the Judiciary"

- and "mechanisms, laws, institutions and Bodies constituted for the protection and betterment of

- these vulnerable sections."

- **Grounded in:** Constitution of India, Art 39A; Legal Services Authorities Act 1987; Family

- Courts Act 1984; Gram Nyayalayas Act 2008; M. Laxmikanth, *Courseware on Indian Polity*, Eighth

- Edition (2026), Ch. 38.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Core Foundation

HIGH

Foundation · Core Foundation · Part 2

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Status legend: □ constitutional/settled static fact · □ statute/rule · □□ judicial holding ·

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATIC THEORY

- □□ analytical inference/current implementation caveat.

- **Core firewall:** This is the consolidated owner for legal-services institutions, ordinary and

- Permanent Lok Adalats, Family Courts and Gram Nyayalayas. Judiciary/body owners should cross-link,

- not reproduce these capsules. It is independently sufficient for Prelims and 10/15/20-mark

- Mains; no Advanced companion is required.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Status legend: constitutional/settled static fact · □ statute/rule · □□ judicial holding ·

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Core Foundation

HIGH

Foundation · Constitutional anchor: access to justice

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□ Article 39A directs the State to secure a legal system promoting justice on equal opportunity and to provide free legal aid so that economic or other disability does not deny access to justice.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

CONSTITUTIONAL ANCHOR: ACCESS TO JUSTICE: RECALL MAP

Constitutional anchor: access to justice

V

Dimension 1 □ Article 39A directs the State to secure a legal system promoting justice on equal opportunity and to provide free legal aid so that economic or othe	**Dimension 2** □□ The Supreme Court has linked meaningful legal aid and speedy justice to fair procedure under Article 21.
Dimension 3 □□ Article 39A is a Directive Principle, but statutes and rights jurisprudence give operational content to its access-to-justice objective.	

STATIC THEORY

- □□ The Supreme Court has linked meaningful legal aid and speedy justice to fair procedure under Article 21.

- □□ Article 39A is a Directive Principle, but statutes and rights jurisprudence give operational content to its access-to-justice objective.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Article 39A directs the State to secure a legal system promoting justice on equal opportunity and to provide free legal aid so that economic or other disability does not deny access to justice.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Constitutional anchor: access to justice

HIGH

Foundation · Legal-services authorities: institutional ladder

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Institution	Key position
NALSA	Lays down policy/principles and frames effective/economical legal-services schemes; Patron-in-Chief is the CJI; Executive Chairman is a serving/retired Supreme Court judge nominated in the statutory manner
Supreme Court Committee	Provides and administers legal services for matters before the Supreme Court
State Authority	Implements Central policy and coordinates State legal services/Lok Adalats; Patron-in-Chief is the Chief Justice of the High Court
High Court Committee	Provides legal services for matters before the High Court
District Authority	Implements programmes and coordinates Taluk activity; District Judge is chairman
Taluk Committee	Coordinates services and Lok Adalats at taluk/mandal level

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Legal-services authorities: institutional ladder

HIGH

Foundation · Legal-services authorities: institutional ladder · Visual 1

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Visual-first reconstruction of the source logic.

LEGAL-SERVICES AUTHORITIES: INSTITUTIONAL LADDER: PROCESS LOGIC

1. National Legal Services Authority (NALSA)	**2.** |
3. Supreme Court Legal Services Committee	**4. State Legal Services Authorities (SLSAs)**
5. High Court Legal Services Committees	**6. District Legal Services Authorities**
7. Taluk Legal Services Committees	

Reading order: left to right, then top to bottom.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Legal-services authorities: institutional ladder

HIGH

Foundation · Legal-services authorities: institutional ladder

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 The Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 creates this structure:

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

LEGAL-SERVICES AUTHORITIES: INSTITUTIONAL LADDER: RECALL MAP

Legal-services authorities: institutional ladder

V

Dimension 1 The Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 creates this structure:	**Dimension 2** Terminology trap: The statutory abbreviation is ordinarily SLSA (State Legal Services
Dimension 3 Authority), not “SALSA”. District and Taluk bodies are commonly abbreviated DLSA and TLSC.	

STATIC THEORY

- **Terminology trap:** The statutory abbreviation is ordinarily **SLSA** (State Legal Services

- Authority), not “SALSA”. District and Taluk bodies are commonly abbreviated DLSA and TLSC.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Legal-services authorities: institutional ladder

HIGH

Foundation · Eligibility for free legal services

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 Section 12 covers specified vulnerable groups, including members of SC/ST, trafficking/begar victims, women or children, persons with disability, disaster/violence victims, industrial workmen, persons in custody and persons below the prescribed income limit. The authority must also be satisfied that there is a prima facie case to prosecute or defend.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

ELIGIBILITY FOR FREE LEGAL SERVICES: RECALL MAP

Eligibility for free legal services

V

Dimension 1 Section 12 covers specified vulnerable groups, including members of SC/ST, trafficking/begar victims, women or children, persons with disability, di	**Dimension 2** Trap: Free legal aid is broader than representation in a criminal trial and is not confined to
Dimension 3 persons below an income threshold; several statutory categories are status-based.	

STATIC THEORY

- **Trap:** Free legal aid is broader than representation in a criminal trial and is not confined to

- persons below an income threshold; several statutory categories are status-based.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Eligibility for free legal services

HIGH

Foundation · Ordinary Lok Adalat

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of Ordinary Lok Adalat.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Ordinary Lok Adalat

HIGH

Foundation · 3.1 Nature and jurisdiction

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 Authorities/committees organise Lok Adalats with serving/retired judicial officers and other prescribed persons. They may handle:

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

3.1 NATURE AND JURISDICTION: RECALL MAP

3.1 Nature and jurisdiction

V

Dimension 1 Authorities/committees organise Lok Adalats with serving/retired judicial officers and other prescribed persons. They may handle:	**Dimension 2** a pending case; or
Dimension 3 a pre-litigation matter falling within a court's jurisdiction,	**Dimension 4** but not an offence that is legally non-compoundable.

STATIC THEORY

- a pending case; or

- a pre-litigation matter falling within a court's jurisdiction,

- but not an offence that is legally non-compoundable.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → 3.1 Nature and jurisdiction

HIGH

Foundation · 3.2 Process and effect · Visual 1

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Visual-first reconstruction of the source logic.

3.2 PROCESS AND EFFECT: PROCESS LOGIC

1. Referral / joint pre-litigation application	**2.** ↓
3. conciliation and compromise effort	**4.** ┌──┴──┐
5. ↓ ↓	**6. settlement no settlement**
7. award = civil- pending case returns;	

Reading order: left to right, then top to bottom.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → 3.2 Process and effect

HIGH

Foundation · 3.2 Process and effect · Part 1

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 The ordinary Lok Adalat:

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

3.2 PROCESS AND EFFECT: RECALL MAP

3.2 Process and effect

V

Dimension 1 The ordinary Lok Adalat:	**Dimension 2** seeks an amicable settlement and is guided by justice, equity, fair play and legal principles;
Dimension 3 cannot compel a compromise or adjudicate the dispute on merits;	**Dimension 4** makes an award when parties settle;

STATIC THEORY

- seeks an amicable settlement and is guided by justice, equity, fair play and legal principles;

- **cannot compel a compromise or adjudicate the dispute on merits**;

- makes an award when parties settle;

- gives the award the status of a civil-court decree;

- makes the award final and binding, with no statutory appeal; and

- enables refund of court fee in a referred case.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional
Advanced Depth → 3.2 Process and effect

HIGH

Foundation · 3.2 Process and effect · Part 2

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 An award based on compromise is ordinarily challengeable only through constitutional review on limited grounds such as absence of genuine consent/fraud—not by a statutory appeal.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATIC THEORY

- **Master trap:** Finality of an agreed award does not authorise a Lok Adalat to impose a merits

- decision when compromise fails.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional
Advanced Depth → 3.2 Process and effect

HIGH

Foundation · 3.3 Forms

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Form	Feature
National/State/District Lok Adalat	General sittings across jurisdictions
Mobile Lok Adalat	Travels to improve access
Mega/continuous/daily Lok Adalat	Administrative formats for volume or regular settlement
E-Lok Adalat	Technology-enabled settlement format

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → 3.3 Forms

HIGH

Foundation · 3.3 Forms

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□□ These formats do not alter the ordinary Lok Adalat's consent-based legal character.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → 3.3 Forms

HIGH

Foundation · Permanent Lok Adalat (PLA)

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□ A Permanent Lok Adalat is established under the Legal Services Authorities Act for one or more **public utility services**. It is permanent in institution and works principally at the pre-litigation stage.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Permanent Lok Adalat (PLA)

HIGH

Foundation · 4.1 Public utility services

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Statutory illustrations include transport, postal/telephone, supply of power/light/water, public conservancy/sanitation, hospital/dispensary and insurance services, plus notified services.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → 4.1 Public utility services

HIGH

Foundation · 4.2 Hybrid process · Visual 1

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Visual-first reconstruction of the source logic.

4.2 HYBRID PROCESS: PROCESS LOGIC

1. Party applies before dispute reaches a court	**2. ↓**
3. PLA conciliates first	**4.**
5. ↓ ↓	**6. settlement conciliation fails**
7. award on settlement PLA may decide merits	

Reading order: left to right, then top to bottom.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → 4.2 Hybrid process

HIGH

Foundation · 4.2 Hybrid process · Part 1

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 Key distinctions:

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

4.2 HYBRID PROCESS: RECALL MAP

4.2 Hybrid process

V

Dimension 1 Key distinctions:	**Dimension 2** jurisdiction is pre-litigation and sector-specific;
Dimension 3 a party cannot invoke another court for that dispute after applying while PLA proceedings	**Dimension 4** continue;

STATIC THEORY

- jurisdiction is pre-litigation and sector-specific;

- a party cannot invoke another court for that dispute after applying while PLA proceedings

- continue;

- PLA first conducts conciliation;

- if conciliation fails, it may decide the dispute on merits, subject to statutory exclusions and

- the Central Government's notified pecuniary limit;

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → 4.2 Hybrid process

HIGH

Foundation · 4.2 Hybrid process · Part 2

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

its award is final, binding, deemed a civil-court decree and not to be called in question in an

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATIC THEORY

- original suit/application/execution proceeding;

- it is guided by natural justice, objectivity, fair play, equity and other principles of justice,

- and is not bound by the CPC or Evidence Act.

- **Trap:** Do not attach a stale rupee ceiling to the Act. The Central Government may revise the

- limit by notification; verify the current notification for a current-affairs answer.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → 4.2 Hybrid process

HIGH

Foundation · Ordinary Lok Adalat versus Permanent Lok Adalat

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Axis	Ordinary Lok Adalat	Permanent Lok Adalat
Statutory route	Ch. VI, 1987 Act	Ch. VI-A, inserted in 2002
Institution	Organised sittings	Standing body
Disputes	Pending or pre-litigation within court jurisdiction	Pre-litigation public-utility disputes
Settlement method	Conciliation/compromise only	Conciliation first
If settlement fails	No merits adjudication	May adjudicate merits
Criminal bar	Non-compoundable offences excluded	Same exclusion
Award	Deemed decree; final and binding	Deemed decree; final and binding

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Ordinary Lok Adalat versus Permanent Lok Adalat

HIGH

Foundation · Ordinary Lok Adalat versus Permanent Lok Adalat

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

The two institutions share statutory finality but not the same jurisdiction or decisional power. An ordinary Lok Adalat depends on compromise; a Permanent Lok Adalat is a pre-litigation public-utility forum that may adjudicate only after its statutory conciliation stage fails.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Ordinary Lok Adalat versus Permanent Lok Adalat

HIGH

Foundation · Family Courts

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Feature	Position
Establishment	State Government, after consultation with High Court; mandatory for specified cities/towns above the statutory population threshold and discretionary elsewhere
Jurisdiction	Matrimonial status, property between spouses, legitimacy, maintenance, guardianship/custody/access and connected family disputes
Primary approach	Endeavour toward settlement before adjudication where consistent with the case
Procedure	Flexible statutory procedure; may receive material that assists effective resolution
Privacy	Proceedings may be held in camera and must be so held if either party desires
Lawyers	No right as of course to legal representation; court may seek legal-expert assistance
Appeal	To High Court from a non-interlocutory judgment/order, subject to statutory exclusions

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Family Courts

HIGH

Foundation · Family Courts

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 The Family Courts Act 1984 provides specialised courts for conciliation and speedy settlement of family/matrimonial disputes.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATIC THEORY

- □□ Specialisation and conciliation do not remove judicial fairness. Family Courts exercise statutory judicial power and differ from compromise-only ordinary Lok Adalats.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Family Courts

HIGH

Foundation · Gram Nyayalayas

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Design element	Position
Establishment	State Government, after consultation with High Court; statutory wording is enabling and implementation is State-dependent
Level	Intermediate Panchayat or group of contiguous Panchayats; headquarters may be mobile
Presiding officer	Nyayadhikari, appointed by State Government in consultation with High Court; qualified for appointment as Judicial Magistrate First Class
Jurisdiction	Specified criminal offences and civil disputes in the Schedules; limits may be altered through statutory process
Territorial access	Mobile court may hold proceedings close to where parties reside/cause arose
Settlement	Endeavour to assist conciliation in civil disputes; conciliators may be used
Procedure	Summary orientation, natural justice and statutory flexibility
Appeals	Criminal appeal to Court of Session; civil appeal to District Court, subject to statutory exceptions

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Gram Nyayalayas

HIGH

Foundation · Gram Nyayalayas

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□ The Gram Nyayalayas Act 2008 seeks doorstep justice in rural areas through courts of first instance.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATIC THEORY

- □□ A Gram Nyayalaya is a statutory court—not a village panchayat, khap, mediation camp or Lok Adalat. Current counts and operational coverage vary and require dated official verification.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Gram Nyayalayas

HIGH

Foundation · Comparative institution map

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Institution	Primary function	Consent needed for outcome?	Can decide merits?	Appeal/control
Ordinary Lok Adalat	Settlement	Yes	No	No statutory appeal; limited judicial review
Permanent Lok Adalat	Public-utility pre-litigation conciliation/adjudication	Not for post-failure merits award	Yes	Statutory finality; constitutional review remains
Family Court	Specialised family adjudication + conciliation	Not for judgment	Yes	Statutory High Court appeal with exclusions
Gram Nyayalaya	Rural first-instance court	Not for judgment	Yes	Session/District appellate routes

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Comparative institution map

HIGH

Foundation · Comparative institution map

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Forum choice depends on the source of jurisdiction, need for consent, power to decide merits and available appeal or review. The same access-to-justice objective can therefore produce very different legal consequences.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Comparative institution map

HIGH

Foundation · Other courts and justice-delivery designs

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Design	Legal source	Core function	UPSC distinction
Fast Track Courts	Government/finance-supported scheme implemented through States and High Courts	Additional capacity for selected pending cases	Not a separate constitutional species or uniform permanent court
Special Courts	Particular statute or valid notification	Trial/adjudication of a defined offence, person or subject	Jurisdiction depends on the parent law
Commercial Courts	Commercial Courts Act 2015, as amended	Specified-value commercial disputes with case-management and pre-institution processes	Statutory civil courts, not tribunals or Lok Adalats
Evening/Morning Courts	High Court/State administrative design under ordinary court authority	Extend hearing hours for suitable minor matters	Administrative format, not a new constitutional hierarchy
Family Courts	Family Courts Act 1984	Family adjudication plus settlement orientation	Judicial decision remains available
Gram Nyayalayas	Gram Nyayalayas Act 2008	Local/mobile first-instance justice	Statutory court with appeals

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Other courts and justice-delivery designs

HIGH

Foundation · Other courts and justice-delivery designs

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□□ A “special”, “fast”, “commercial” or “evening” label identifies a design or jurisdiction. It does not by itself answer appointment, procedure, appeal or constitutional status.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Other courts and justice-delivery designs

HIGH

Foundation · Mediation Act 2023 interface · Visual 1

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Visual-first reconstruction of the source logic.

MEDIATION ACT 2023 INTERFACE: PROCESS LOGIC

1. MEDIATION	**2. neutral facilitates party-made settlement**
3. ≠	**4. ORDINARY LOK ADALAT**
5. statutory forum records compromise as award/deemed decree	**6. PERMANENT LOK ADALAT**
7. conciliation first; eligible public-utility dispute may then be decided on merits	

Reading order: left to right, then top to bottom.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Mediation Act 2023 interface

HIGH

Foundation · Mediation Act 2023 interface

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 The Mediation Act 2023 supplies a general statutory framework for mediation, including pre-litigation, institutional, online and community-mediation concepts, mediated-settlement agreements, confidentiality and enforcement/challenge rules. Its commencement, rules and any sectoral exclusions must be checked provision by provision on the control date.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATIC THEORY

- The Commercial Courts Act's pre-institution mediation route and the Mediation Act must not be collapsed into the Lok Adalat regime. Settlement remains party-made in mediation; an ordinary Lok Adalat award follows compromise; a PLA has a limited post-conciliation adjudicatory power.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Mediation Act 2023 interface

HIGH

Foundation · Courts, tribunals and ADR

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Axis	Court	Tribunal	ADR/mediation	Lok Adalat
Source	Constitution/statute and judicial hierarchy	Statute under constitutional limits	Contract/statute/court referral	Legal Services Authorities Act
Primary role	Adjudication	Specialised adjudication	Facilitated/party-chosen resolution	Statutory settlement; PLA hybrid
Binding outcome without consent	Yes	Yes	Generally no mediated settlement without consent	Ordinary: no; PLA: yes after failed conciliation within scope
Appeal/review	Hierarchical/statutory	Statutory appeal plus constitutional review	Enforcement/challenge under governing law	Statutory finality plus limited constitutional review

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Courts, tribunals and ADR

HIGH

Foundation · Courts, tribunals and ADR

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Trap: “Alternative forum” does not mean identical power. Consent, subject matter,

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATIC THEORY

- pre-litigation status, merits power, enforcement and review must be tested separately.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Courts, tribunals and ADR

HIGH

Foundation · Leading cases and legal effects

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Decision	Decision year	Exam-safe holding/use
Hussainara Khatoon v. State of Bihar	1979	Speedy justice and legal assistance are integral to fair procedure under Art 21
State of Punjab v. Jalour Singh	2008	Ordinary Lok Adalat has no adjudicatory role; award must rest on compromise
Afcons Infrastructure v. Cherian Varkey Construction	2010	Structured guidance on court referral to ADR processes
InterGlobe Aviation v. N. Satchidanand	2011	Ordinary Lok Adalat and Permanent Lok Adalat are legally distinct; merits power cannot be casually transferred
Bar Council of India v. Union of India	2012	Upheld the PLA public-utility conciliation-cum-adjudication design
Patil Automation v. Rakheja Engineers	2022	Commercial pre-institution mediation requirement is mandatory where the statutory urgent-relief exception does not apply
Canara Bank v. G.S. Jayarama	2022	Clarified PLA conciliation procedure and its limited power to decide an eligible dispute after conciliation fails

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Leading cases and legal effects

HIGH

Foundation · Leading cases and legal effects

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□□ Case use must track the exact statutory mechanism. A decision about commercial mediation, ordinary Lok Adalat or PLA cannot be applied as if all three were the same forum.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Leading cases and legal effects

HIGH

Foundation · Constitutional significance and implementation limits

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of Constitutional significance and implementation limits.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Constitutional significance and implementation limits

HIGH

Foundation · Advantages

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

lowers cost, distance and procedural complexity;

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

ADVANTAGES: RECALL MAP

Advantages

V

Dimension 1 lowers cost, distance and procedural complexity;	**Dimension 2** improves access for vulnerable litigants;
Dimension 3 promotes conciliation where continuing relationships matter;	**Dimension 4** diverts suitable disputes from regular courts;

STATIC THEORY

- improves access for vulnerable litigants;
- promotes conciliation where continuing relationships matter;
- diverts suitable disputes from regular courts;
- combines legal aid with institutional access.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Advantages

HIGH

Foundation · Limits

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

settlement systems risk pressure or unequal bargaining if consent is not real;

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

LIMITS: RECALL MAP

Limits

V

Dimension 1 settlement systems risk pressure or unequal bargaining if consent is not real;	**Dimension 2** specialised/local institutions need judges, staff, awareness and infrastructure;
Dimension 3 statutory finality cannot cure jurisdictional error or denial of natural justice;	**Dimension 4** low utilisation or uneven State implementation may prevent designed access from becoming actual

STATIC THEORY

- specialised/local institutions need judges, staff, awareness and infrastructure;

- statutory finality cannot cure jurisdictional error or denial of natural justice;

- low utilisation or uneven State implementation may prevent designed access from becoming actual

- access.

- □□ ADR is a complement, not a wholesale substitute, for independent courts. The constitutional test is affordable access **with** voluntariness, fairness and review against illegality.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Limits

HIGH

Foundation · Answer architecture (10/15/20-mark support)

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of Answer architecture (10/15/20-mark support).

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Answer architecture (10/15/20-mark support)

HIGH

Foundation · 14.1 Demand map

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Demand	Answer spine
Lok Adalat significance	Art 39A → statutory design → consent/finality → access gains → safeguards
Ordinary versus PLA	jurisdiction → stage → conciliation → merits power → award
Alternative justice institutions	legal-services ladder → four institutions → comparative matrix → implementation
Gram Nyayalayas	statutory design → mobile/local jurisdiction → appellate safeguard → operational gaps
Family Courts	specialisation → conciliation/privacy/flexibility → fairness/capacity

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → 14.1 Demand map

HIGH

Foundation · 14.2 Thesis options

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

*Lok Adalats constitutionalise access through consensual settlement, but their legitimacy depends

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

14.2 THESIS OPTIONS: RECALL MAP

14.2 Thesis options

V

Dimension 1 Lok Adalats constitutionalise access through consensual settlement, but their legitimacy depends	**Dimension 2** on genuine compromise rather than docket disposal.
Dimension 3 The Permanent Lok Adalat is a hybrid: conciliation remains first, but limited statutory	**Dimension 4** adjudication follows failure in public-utility disputes.

STATIC THEORY

- on genuine compromise rather than docket disposal.*

- *The Permanent Lok Adalat is a hybrid: conciliation remains first, but limited statutory

- adjudication follows failure in public-utility disputes.*

- *India's access-to-justice architecture is plural, yet statutory proximity must be matched by

- personnel, awareness and procedural fairness.*

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → 14.2 Thesis options

HIGH

Foundation · 14.3 Mark-scaled structures

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Marks	Structure	Evidence
10	Art 39A → design → 2 distinctions → verdict	3–4 statutory features
15	Institutional ladder → ordinary/PLA comparison → benefits/limits	5–6 anchors
20	Constitutional anchor → four-institution matrix → safeguards → implementation reform → conclusion	7–9 anchors

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → 14.3 Mark-scaled structures

HIGH

Foundation · 14.4 Evidence units

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Claim: an ordinary Lok Adalat is conciliatory, not adjudicatory. **Evidence:** □ compromise

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

14.4 EVIDENCE UNITS: RECALL MAP

14.4 Evidence units

V

Dimension 1 Claim: an ordinary Lok Adalat is conciliatory, not adjudicatory. Evidence: compromise	**Dimension 2** design and award provisions. Analysis: consent legitimises finality. Qualification: limited constitutional challenge remains.
Dimension 3 Claim: PLA fills a pre-litigation public-service gap. Evidence: public-utility and	**Dimension 4** post-conciliation merits powers. Analysis: combines settlement with enforceable resolution. Qualification: jurisdiction is sectoral and notification-s

STATIC THEORY

- design and award provisions. **Analysis:** consent legitimises finality. **Qualification:** limited constitutional challenge remains.

- **Claim:** PLA fills a pre-litigation public-service gap. **Evidence:** public-utility and

- post-conciliation merits powers. **Analysis:** combines settlement with enforceable resolution. **Qualification:** jurisdiction is sectoral and notification-sensitive.

- **Claim:** proximity alone does not ensure justice. **Evidence:** mobile Gram Nyayalaya design.

- **Analysis:** reduces distance. **Qualification:** State establishment, staffing and awareness determine actual access.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → 14.4 Evidence units

HIGH

Foundation · Must-Know Facts and traps · Part 1

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

 Art 39A is the constitutional anchor.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MUST-KNOW FACTS AND TRAPS: RECALL MAP

Must-Know Facts and traps

V

Dimension 1 Art 39A is the constitutional anchor.	**Dimension 2** Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 creates the authority ladder and Lok Adalats.
Dimension 3 Ordinary Lok Adalat cannot decide merits after failed compromise.	**Dimension 4** PLA may decide merits after failed conciliation in eligible public-utility disputes.

STATIC THEORY

- □ Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 creates the authority ladder and Lok Adalats.
- □ Ordinary Lok Adalat cannot decide merits after failed compromise.
- □ PLA may decide merits after failed conciliation in eligible public-utility disputes.
- □ Both awards are treated as civil-court decrees and are final/binding.
- □ Family Courts and Gram Nyayalayas are statutory courts with adjudicatory power.
- □ Fast Track Courts and evening courts are designs/schemes; special and commercial courts

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Art 39A is the constitutional anchor.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Must-Know Facts and traps

HIGH

Foundation · Must-Know Facts and traps · Part 2

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

derive jurisdiction from their governing law.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATIC THEORY

- □ Mediation, ordinary Lok Adalat and PLA have different consent and merits-decision rules.
- □□ Current pecuniary limits, notified services and operational counts require dated official
- verification.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Must-Know Facts and traps

HIGH

Foundation · Source discipline

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Never use "people's court" to imply absence of law or fairness.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

SOURCE DISCIPLINE: RECALL MAP

Source discipline

V

Dimension 1 Never use "people's court" to imply absence of law or fairness.	**Dimension 2** Do not say all Lok Adalat disputes are pre-litigation.
Dimension 3 Do not say no legal challenge of any kind can ever lie against an award.	**Dimension 4** Do not merge Permanent Lok Adalat with an ordinary permanent sitting.

STATIC THEORY

- Do not say all Lok Adalat disputes are pre-litigation.
- Do not say no legal challenge of any kind can ever lie against an award.
- Do not merge Permanent Lok Adalat with an ordinary permanent sitting.
- Do not call Gram Nyayalaya a Panchayat institution.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Source discipline

HIGH

Foundation · Cross-links

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

High Court supervision/review: High-Court.md

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

CROSS-LINKS: RECALL MAP

Cross-links

V

Dimension 1 High Court supervision/review: High-Court.md	**Dimension 2** Tribunals and specialised adjudication: Administrative-Tribunals.md
Dimension 3 Statutory/quasi-judicial bodies: Statutory-Regulatory-and-Quasi-Judicial-Bodies.md	**Dimension 4** DPSP context: Directive-Principles.md

STATIC THEORY

- Tribunals and specialised adjudication: Administrative-Tribunals.md
- Statutory/quasi-judicial bodies: Statutory-Regulatory-and-Quasi-Judicial-Bodies.md
- DPSP context: Directive-Principles.md

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Cross-links

HIGH

Foundation · Semantic-completeness ownership and PYQ control

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of Semantic-completeness ownership and PYQ control.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

Constitutional anchor: *Article 39A directs equal-opportunity justice and free legal aid. Article 21 jurisprudence supplies fair-procedure and speedy- justice reinforcement; Article 39A does not itself create every forum.* ***Institutional ladder:*** *the Legal Services Authorities Act, 1987 creates NALSA, the Supreme Court Committee, SLSAs, High Court Committees, DLSAs and Taluk Committees. Section 12 combines status-based vulnerability categories with prescribed income eligibility and a prima-facie-case gate.* ***Ordinary Lok Adalat:*** *it handles pending or pre-litigation matters within court jurisdiction, excluding non-compoundable offences, and can only facilitate compromise. Jalour Singh confirms that failure of settlement returns the matter to the ordinary route; no merits award may be imposed.* ***Ordinary award:*** *a genuine settlement award is deemed a civil-court decree, final and binding with no statutory appeal. Finality does not cure fraud, absence of consent, jurisdictional error or constitutional illegality.* ***Permanent Lok Adalat:*** *Chapter VI-A creates a standing pre-litigation public-utility forum. It conciliates first and, after failed conciliation, may decide an eligible dispute on merits within statutory exclusions and the currently notified pecuniary framework.* ***Court firewall:*** *Gram Nyayalayas and Family Courts are statutory courts capable of adjudication with defined appeal routes. Fast-track courts are capacity schemes; special and commercial courts derive jurisdiction from their parent law. Labels do not determine constitutional status.* ***ADR firewall:*** *mediation produces a party-made settlement, arbitration an adjudicatory award, ordinary Lok Adalat a compromise award, and Permanent Lok Adalat a limited post-conciliation merits decision. Consent and review differ.* ***Mediation commencement:*** *S.O. 4384(E) commenced only sections 1, 3, 26, 31-38, 45-47, 50-54 and 56-57 on 9 October 2023. Unnotified sections must not be described as fully operative.* ***2026 institutional update:*** *S.O. 4781(E), dated 27 August 2026, established the Mediation Council of India under section 31(1), with head office at Delhi. Establishment does not retrospectively commence every provision of the Act.* ***Implementation control:*** *Gram Nyayalaya, Family Court, Lok Adalat and legal aid counts are date-sensitive. Access must be evaluated through voluntariness, counsel quality, staffing, distance, digital inclusion, reasons and review.* ***Official-source control, checked 5 September 2026:*** *NALSA, India Code, Department of Justice, Parliament and Gazette sources control. The verified 2020, 2023 and 2024 demands remain routed without inventing an official key.*

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Semantic-completeness ownership and PYQ control

HIGH

Advanced · Core Foundation

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Companion to basic/Lok-Adalats-and-Other-Courts.md.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATIC THEORY

- Apply only after the complete statutory and comparative Core.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Core Foundation

HIGH

Advanced · Dispute-system design

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the advanced source layer.

KEY DATA

Dispute characteristic	Suitable design consideration
Continuing relationship	conciliation/mediation with consent safeguards
Urgent coercive relief	court with enforceable interim jurisdiction
Technical recurring field	specialised court/tribunal with review
Low-value local claim	accessible first-instance forum and simplified procedure
Public-utility pre-litigation dispute	PLA only within statutory jurisdiction

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Dispute-system design

HIGH

Advanced · Dispute-system design

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

A justice system should match forum to dispute:

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

STATIC THEORY

- No forum should be chosen merely to improve disposal statistics.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Dispute-system design

HIGH

Advanced · Consent quality and power asymmetry

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Settlement legitimacy requires informed consent, access to advice, absence of intimidation, understanding of consequences and neutral facilitation. Women, workers, accident victims, consumers and persons with limited digital access may face unequal bargaining power. A signed settlement is therefore not the end of the fairness inquiry where fraud, coercion or jurisdictional defect is credibly alleged.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Consent quality and power asymmetry

HIGH

Advanced · Digital justice

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

E-Lok Adalats and online mediation can reduce travel and scheduling cost, but require identity assurance, private communication, document access, language support, disability access and an offline alternative. Digital convenience must not become a condition for accessing justice.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Digital justice

HIGH

Advanced · Reform metrics · Part 1

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Evaluate access institutions by:

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

REFORM METRICS: RECALL MAP

Reform metrics

V

Dimension 1 Evaluate access institutions by:	**Dimension 2** time and cost saved;
Dimension 3 representation and informed-consent quality;	**Dimension 4** settlement durability and compliance;

STATIC THEORY

- time and cost saved;

- representation and informed-consent quality;

- settlement durability and compliance;

- geographic and social reach;

- reasoned handling of failed settlement;

- staffing, infrastructure and legal-aid quality; and

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Reform metrics

HIGH

Advanced · Reform metrics · Part 2

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

review of jurisdictional or natural-justice error.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK
Lok Adalats and Other Courts — Optional Advanced Depth → Reform metrics

End of Register Notes - UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI